C1 Grammar

Inversion for emphasis

Using 'Never have I...', 'Not only...' and 'Little did they...' in formal writing.

After certain negative or restrictive expressions placed at the start of a sentence, English inverts the subject and auxiliary, as in a question. This adds emphasis and a formal tone.

Opening expression	Example
Never / Rarely / Seldom	*Rarely have I seen such dedication.*
Not only … but also	*Not only did she win, but she also broke the record.*
Hardly / Scarcely … when	*Hardly had we arrived when it started to rain.*
No sooner … than	*No sooner had he sat down than the phone rang.*
Little	*Little did they know what was coming.*
Only then / Only after / Only when	*Only when I left did I realise my mistake.*
Under no circumstances	*Under no circumstances should you open this door.*

Need an auxiliary? If the normal sentence has no auxiliary, add *do / does / did*: *She rarely complains* becomes *Rarely does she complain.*

With 'only', the inversion is in the main clause. *Only after the meeting did I understand*, not *Only after did the meeting I understand*.

Practice

1. I have never been so embarrassed. → Never ___
2. He didn't know that he was being followed. → Little ___
3. As soon as she got home, she fell asleep. → No sooner ___
4. You must not tell anyone. → Under no circumstances ___

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Never have I been so embarrassed.
2. Little did he know that he was being followed.
3. No sooner had she got home than she fell asleep.
4. Under no circumstances must you tell anyone.